

An Act

ENROLLED HOUSE
BILL NO. 3710

By: Caldwell (Chad) of the
House

and

Pugh of the Senate

An Act relating to education; amending 70 O.S. 2021, Section 2403, as amended by Section 3, Chapter 482, O.S.L. 2025 (70 O.S. Supp. 2025, Section 2403), which relates to eligibility requirements for the Oklahoma Rising Scholars Award Program; authorizing the State Regents to establish cohort-based award schedules; permitting cohort-based award schedule amounts and structure to vary by academic year; and providing an effective date.

SUBJECT: Education

BE IT ENACTED BY THE PEOPLE OF THE STATE OF OKLAHOMA:

SECTION 1. AMENDATORY 70 O.S. 2021, Section 2403, as amended by Section 3, Chapter 482, O.S.L. 2025 (70 O.S. Supp. 2025, Section 2403), is amended to read as follows:

Section 2403. A. No person shall be eligible to participate in the Oklahoma Rising Scholars Award Program unless the person:

1. Has complied with all of the rules promulgated by the Oklahoma State Regents for Higher Education pursuant to the provisions of the Oklahoma Rising Scholars Award Act, Section 2401 et seq. of this title, for the award, regulation, and administration of scholarships; and

2. Qualifies as one of the following:

- a. an Individual Applicant Qualified Student, which shall mean a student who is a resident of the State of

Oklahoma whose American College Testing Program score or whose Scholastic Aptitude Test score falls within the 99.5 to 100.0 percentile levels as administered in the State of Oklahoma and whose grade point average and/or class rank is exceptional, as determined by the State Regents,

- b. a Presidential Scholar, which shall mean a student selected by the Commission on Presidential Scholars administered by the United States Department of Education,
- c. a National Merit Scholar, which shall mean a student designated as a National Merit Scholar by the National Merit Scholarship Corporation,
- d. a National Merit Finalist, which shall mean a student designated as a National Merit Finalist by the National Merit Scholarship Corporation, or
- e. after October 1, 1999, an Institutional Nominee, which shall mean a student nominated by an institution in The Oklahoma State System of Higher Education:
 - (1) whose American College Testing Program or Scholastic Aptitude Test score falls within the 95.0 to 99.49 percentile levels, or
 - (2) who shows exceptional academic achievement as evidenced by factors, including, but not limited to, grade point average, class rank, national awards, scholastic achievements, honors, and who shows exceptional promise based on documentation that may include, but not be limited to, teacher recommendations, extracurricular activities, and evidence of overcoming economic and social obstacles as determined by the State Regents. The State Regents shall ensure that standards of high academic ability are documented. Scholarship awards to Institutional Nominees shall become effective when appropriate documentation is verified by the State Regents.

B. No person shall be eligible to receive a scholarship pursuant to the provisions of the Oklahoma Rising Scholars Award

Program unless the person is enrolled as a full-time student at a public or private accredited institution of higher education in Oklahoma.

C. For a student who qualifies pursuant to subparagraphs a through d of paragraph 2 of subsection A of this section and subject to the availability of funds, the Oklahoma Rising Scholars Award Program shall provide a scholarship in an amount not to exceed the costs of all enrollment fees, tuition and other fees, room and board, and all required textbooks or materials for up to five (5) years of undergraduate and/or graduate study at an accredited public or private institution of higher education in Oklahoma. The State Regents may establish separate scholarship award levels for each qualifying category.

1. If the student is attending an institution within The Oklahoma State System of Higher Education, the total funding for the scholarship provided in this subsection, exclusive of any internships, shall not exceed the costs for items specified in this subsection at the institution attended as determined annually by the Oklahoma State Regents for Higher Education.

2. If the student is attending a private institution of higher education, the total funding for the scholarship provided in this subsection, exclusive of any internships, shall not exceed the costs for items specified in this subsection at an institution of The Oklahoma State System of Higher Education of comparable type which has the highest general enrollment fees of its type of institution in The Oklahoma State System of Higher Education as determined annually by the Oklahoma State Regents for Higher Education.

D. For a student who qualifies pursuant to subparagraph e of paragraph 2 of subsection A of this section and subject to the availability of funds, the Oklahoma Rising Scholars Award Program shall provide a scholarship in an amount not to exceed the average costs of all enrollment fees and other fees, room and board, and all required textbooks or materials for up to five (5) years of undergraduate and/or graduate study at an accredited public or private institution of higher education in Oklahoma. The State Regents may establish separate scholarship award levels for each qualifying category.

1. If the student is attending an institution within The Oklahoma State System of Higher Education, the institution shall provide a tuition waiver not to exceed the average cost of tuition.

The total funding for the scholarship and waiver provided for students attending an institution within The Oklahoma State System of Higher Education as provided in this subsection, exclusive of any internships, shall not exceed the costs for items specified in this subsection at the institution attended as determined annually by the Oklahoma State Regents for Higher Education.

2. If the student is attending a private institution of higher education in Oklahoma, the scholarship shall include an amount not to exceed the average cost of tuition. The total funding for scholarships for students attending a private institution as provided in this subsection, exclusive of any internships, shall not exceed the costs for items specified in this subsection at an institution within The Oklahoma State System of Higher Education of comparable type which has the highest general enrollment fees of its type of institution in The Oklahoma State System of Higher Education as determined annually by the Oklahoma State Regents for Higher Education.

E. If a person identifies himself or herself as a student with a disability and requests consideration for a scholarship under the Oklahoma Rising Scholars Award Program by means other than standard testing procedures, the State Regents shall determine what means of assessment are appropriate and upon the basis of said assessment results, determine what level of award, if any, shall be made.

F. The State Regents may establish cohort-based award schedules for the Oklahoma Rising Scholars Award Program. The cohort-based award schedule amount and structure of scholarship funding applicable to a recipient may vary by the academic year in which the recipient is first awarded under the Oklahoma Rising Scholars Award Act.

SECTION 2. This act shall become effective November 1, 2026.

Passed the House of Representatives the 23rd day of March, 2026.

Presiding Officer of the House
of Representatives

Passed the Senate the 5th day of May, 2026.

Presiding Officer of the Senate

OFFICE OF THE GOVERNOR

Received by the Office of the Governor this _____
day of _____, 20_____, at _____ o'clock _____ M.
By: _____

Approved by the Governor of the State of Oklahoma this _____
day of _____, 20_____, at _____ o'clock _____ M.

Governor of the State of Oklahoma

OFFICE OF THE SECRETARY OF STATE

Received by the Office of the Secretary of State this _____
day of _____, 20_____, at _____ o'clock _____ M.
By: _____